

up Goel and Bhutoria. They couldn't offer any justification to the events unfolding. Early morning, the police came. I thought they were taking me to the airport so that I could return to Kolkata. Later, I understood I was being dumped to Delhi.

Q. What do you want now?

A. All I want is to return to Kolkata and resume writing from my residence. Let the Centre take a decision so that I can live there. I don't want to be harassed any more, pressured any more. I am a Bengali. I write in Bengali. Bangladesh has closed the doors on me. I can't exist as a writer if I am not allowed to live in West Bengal.

Q. Yesterday, Narendra Modi invited you to Gujarat. What's your take on that?

A. There's no question of my staying in Gujarat. BJP is trying to take the political advantage. I never wrote anything detrimental to Islam. It's all politics. Effort is on to incite the Muslims so that I could be deported.

Q. Don't you find any difference between what happened in Dhaka in 1994 and the events in Kolkata?

A. Politically, it's almost identical. The fundamentalists marched in Dhaka in bigger numbers. But they didn't torch public vehicles. They didn't burn my effigy. The Dhaka Police didn't play the spectator. They opened fire once demonstrations turned violent. Arrests were made. They didn't exert mental pressure on me to leave the country. This happened only in Kolkata.

Q. You made calls to Pranab Mukherjee. Didn't you speak to Buddhadeb Bhattacharya?

A. I tried several times. After he banned Dwikhandito, he never met me. He decided to avoid me. But he sent people telling me to leave the country.

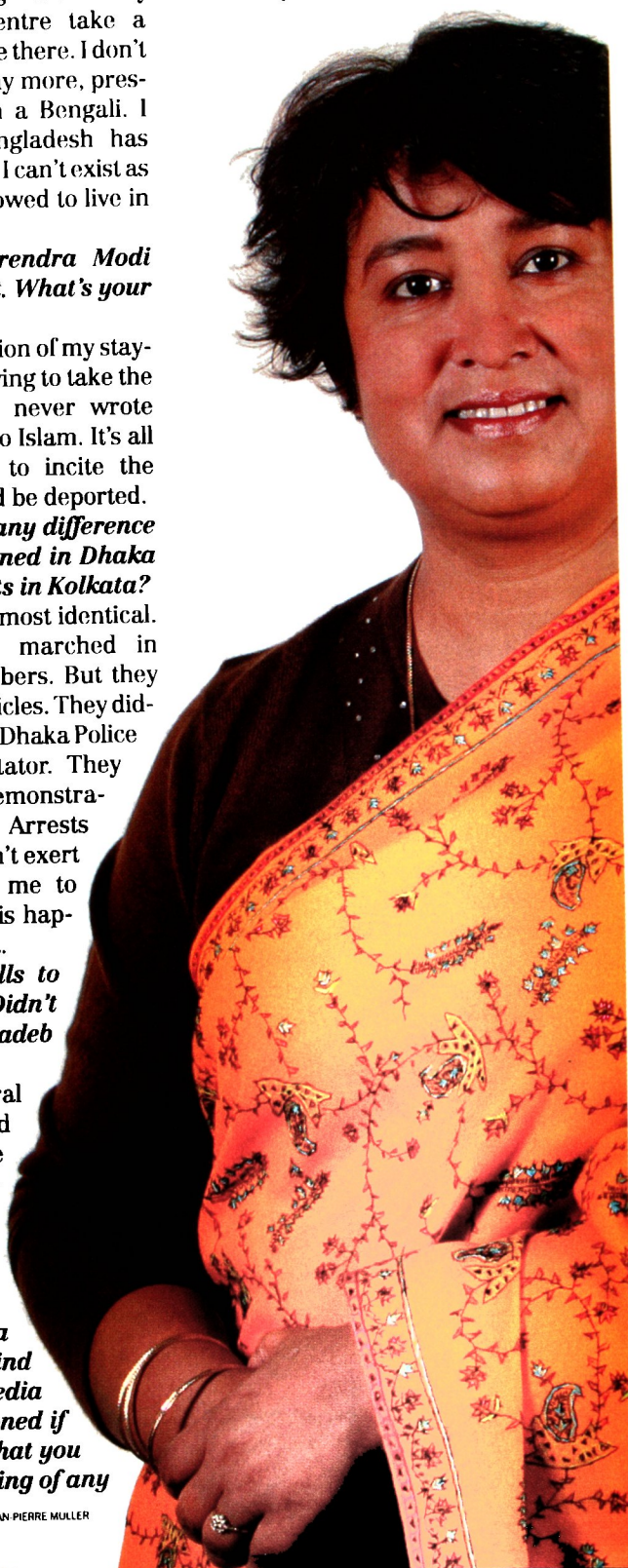
Q. Last night a Jamat-e-Ulema-e-Hind leader told the media that you'll be pardoned if you say sorry for what you have written. Thinking of any

public statement?

A. I have made statements. I said, "I am sorry if I have hurt anybody's sentiment through my writings."

Q. Your tourist visa will expire after February 17. What will you do if the Government refuses to extend it? Leave for some other land?

A. No, I can't think of any alternative. I only want to return to Kolkata.



a clause. "It is expected that the guests will refrain from activities and expressions that may hurt the sentiments of our people." BJP's deputy leader in the Lok Sabha, V.K. Malhotra, was not satisfied: "He has not explained what her status is now. Will she go back to Kolkata? Will the Government extend her visa? Where is she now? Why was she removed from Kolkata and then from Rajasthan?"

With the Gujarat elections a few weeks away, the Congress is playing its Muslim card with utmost caution. And who is in a better position than Narendra Modi to seize the moment? "Taslima has been courageous in speaking out against fundamentalists. If the Central Government cannot look after her, send her to Gujarat. The people and the Government of Gujarat will look after her. I have the courage to protect her." Scoffing at Modi's invitation, Information and Broadcasting Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi wondered whether Modi was trying to atone for his post-Godhra sins. Even VIP's Ashok Singhal has suddenly become the champion of free speech: "We are in support of freedom of expression." RSS chief K. Sudarshan too wants the Government to grant the displaced writer "political asylum".

The Sangh Parivar's sudden espousal of the right to free speech may be purely political. Still, BJP as the opposition party could not have got a better opportunity than Nasreen's homelessness to exploit the secular dubiousness of both the Congress and the communists, parties that have profited immensely from the official industrialisation of secularism. (After all, it was BJP in power that allowed Salman Rushdie to visit India after *The Satanic Verses* ban). Congress is already aware that a section of the Muslim community is disillusioned with it for reasons ranging from economic to foreign policies. The UPA Government could keep her in the safe house till her Indian visa expires in February. The Congress—or the Government—is vague about what it will do with her after that.

As for the Marxists, the Centre's takeover provides them with an escape route. "It is the prerogative of the Centre," CPI(M) leader Sitaram Yechury